The Thief's Story

Class 10 English | Footprints Without Feet | By Ruskin Bond

Central Idea

A heartwarming tale of how pure trust, human connection, and the promise of education can transform a hardened thief into a better human being.

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The Predator and The Easy Target

Hari Singh
(The Narrator)

- 15 years old.
- Experienced and a fairly successful hand at theft.
- Takes a new name every month to dodge the police.

The Approach:

Hari uses flattery: “You look a bit of a wrestler yourself.”

He deploys his most appealing smile to win Anil’s confidence and find a new target.

Anil

- About 25 years old.
- Tall, lean, easy-going.
- Kind and simple enough for the thief’s purpose.

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Securing Shelter Through the First Lies

Step 1: The Bargain. Hari asks for work. Anil has no money to pay him but offers to feed him if he can cook. Hari lies and says he can.

Step 2: The Terrible Meal. Anil brings Hari to a room over the Jumna Sweet Shop. The food is so atrocious that Anil gives it to a stray dog and tells Hari to leave.

Step 3: The Winning Smile. Hari refuses to leave, just hanging around and smiling. Anil cannot help but laugh, pats his head, and lets him stay on the balcony.

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The Promise of a Respected Future

What Anil Teaches:

- How to cook properly.
- How to write his own name.
- The Ultimate Promise: To teach him to write whole sentences and add numbers.

Hari's Realization

"I knew that once I could write like an educated man there would be no limit to what I could achieve."

Insight: Hari sees education as a permanent tool for success, far more powerful than petty theft.

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Absolute Freedom vs. The Daily Rupee

Total Trust

- Anil gives Hari a key to the door.
- Hari can come and go with absolute freedom.
- Hari's note: "He was the most trusting person I had ever met."

Petty Skimming

- Hari buys the day's supplies.
- He secretly makes a profit of about one rupee a day.
- Anil likely knows, but does not seem to mind.

The Thief's Dilemma: Robbing a greedy man is easy; robbing a careless, trusting man takes all the pleasure out of the work because he might not even notice.

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The ₹600 Temptation Under the Mattress

Anil's Irregular Income:

- Earns money by fits and starts (writes for magazines—a queer way to make a living).
- Sells a book to a publisher and brings home a bundle of notes.

Hari's Justification:

- "I'm out of practice."
- "If I don't take it, he'll only waste it on his friends."
- "He doesn't even pay me."

The Act:

- Under the moonlight, Hari silently draws out the notes.
- He counts them on the road: 600 rupees in fifties.

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The 10:30 Lucknow Express and the Unexplained Hesitation

The Escape Plan:

- Live luxuriously like an oil-rich Arab for a week or two.
- Catch the 10:30 Express to Lucknow.

The Hesitation:

- Hari dashes to the platform (having never bought a ticket in his life).
- The train is moving; he could easily jump into a carriage.
- But he hesitates—for a reason he cannot explain.

The Aftermath:

- The train vanishes. Hari is left completely alone on a deserted platform with nowhere to go and no friends.

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Faces of the Robbed and the True Cost of Theft

The Thief's Study of Human Reactions:

- Greedy man → Shows fear
- Rich man → Shows anger
- Poor man → Shows acceptance

Anil's Reaction:

- Will show only a touch of sadness.
- Not for the loss of money, but for the loss of trust.

The Epiphany.

In the excitement of the theft, Hari forgot about the whole sentences. Stealing is a simple matter. But to be a 'really big man, a clever and respected man' requires education. He must return to learn.

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The Hardest Act: Returning the Money

The Key Insight: “It is much easier to steal something than to return it undetected.”

The Return Sequence:

Step 1:
Hurries back to the room, feeling extremely nervous.

Step 2:
Stands frozen in the doorway under clouded moonlight.

Step 3:
Creeps to the head of the bed, feeling Anil's warm breath on his hand.

Step 4:
Successfully slips the damp notes back under the mattress.

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The Next Morning and the Wet ₹50 Note

The Setup:

- Hari wakes up late; Anil has already made the morning tea.

The Scare:

- Anil stretches out his hand holding a **fifty-rupee note.**
- Hari's heart sinks—he is certain he has been discovered.

The Reveal:

- Anil explains: "I made some money yesterday. Now you'll be paid regularly."
- Hari takes the note. He touches it and realizes it is still **wet from the night's rain.**

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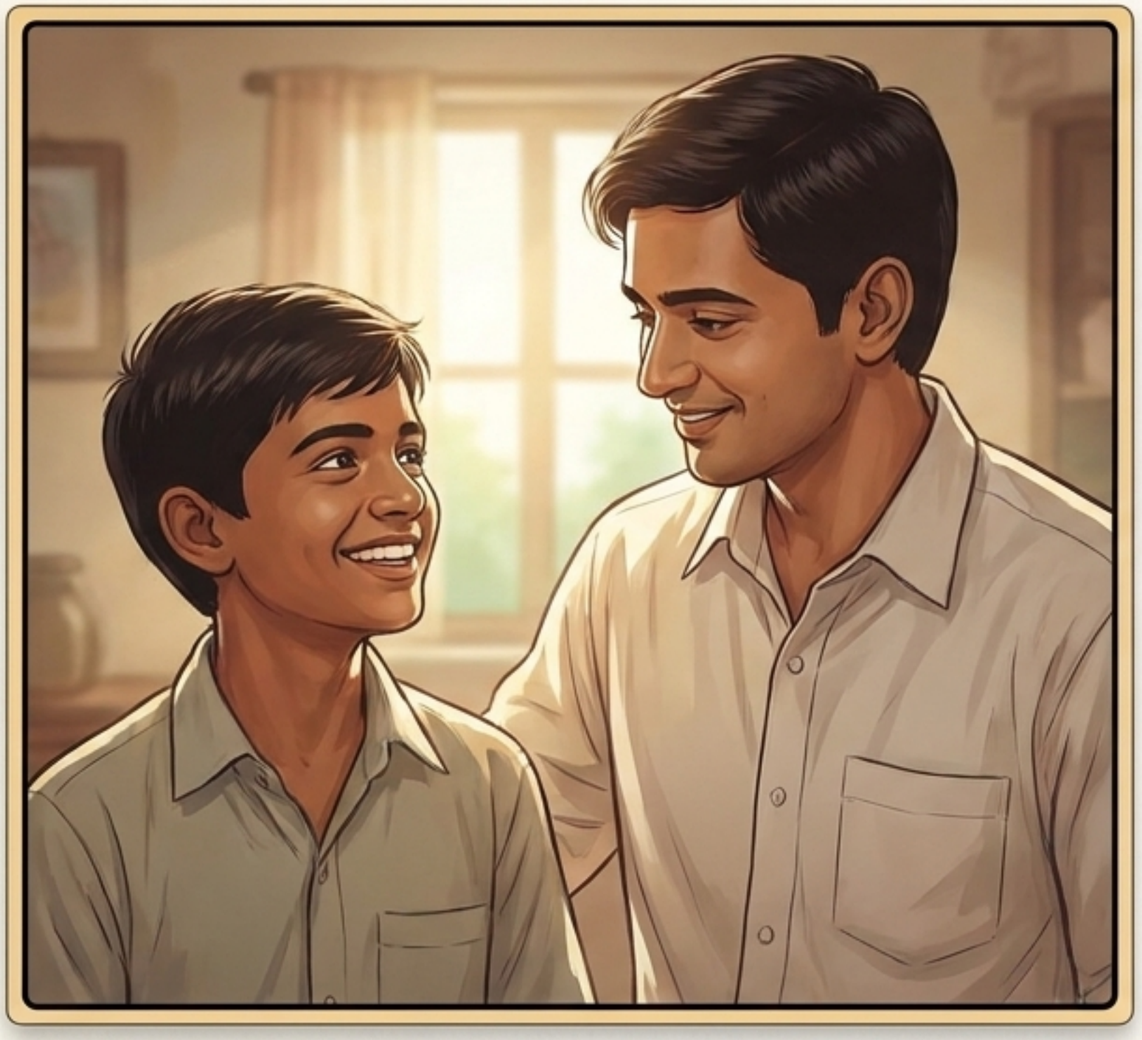
The Reforming Power of Silent Forgiveness



Anil’s Choice:

- Anil says: “Today we’ll start writing sentences.”
- He absolutely knew about the theft and the return.
- But neither his lips nor his eyes showed anything. He chooses grace over punishment.

Hari's Transformation:

- Hari smiles at Anil in his "most appealing way."
- Unlike his earlier calculated smiles, this one came by itself, without any effort. The thief is gone; the student remains.

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Character Diagnostics: Hari Singh vs. Anil

Dimension	Hari Singh (The Thief)	Anil (The Writer)
Age & Role	15, experienced thief	~25, struggling writer
Personality	Cunning, observant, adaptable	Easy-going, kind, trusting
View on Money	A means to survive and buy luxury	Careless, celebrates when paid
Reaction to Trust	Initially exploits it, eventually respects it	Gives it freely and completely
Ultimate Act	Chooses education and dignity over quick cash	Chooses silent forgiveness over police punishment

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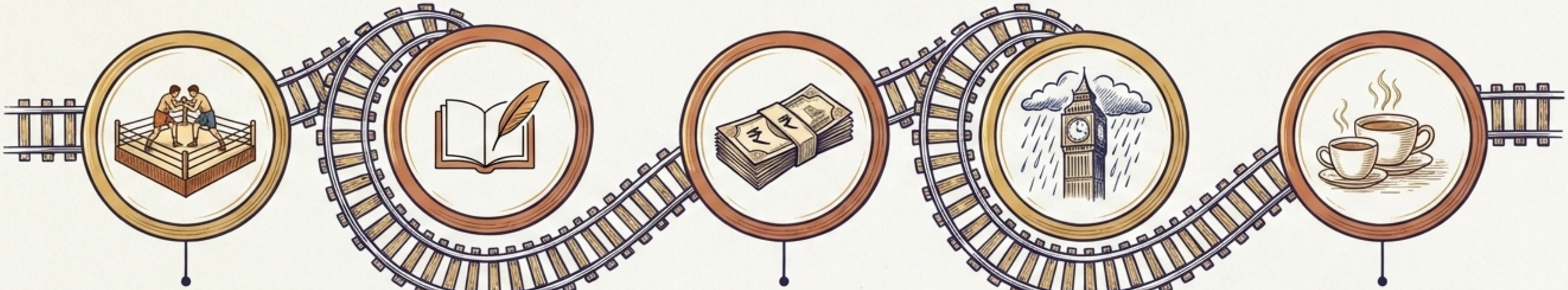
Super Revision: The Plot at a Glance



The Meeting:
Hari targets Anil at a match, match, lies about cooking, and gets a place on the balcony.

The Education:
Anil teaches Hari to write and trusts him with keys;

Hari skims daily grocery money.

The Theft:
The threft: Anil brings home ₹600. Hari steals it at midnight and flees to the station.

The Conflict:

Hari misses the Lucknow Express, realizing he is trading a respected future for temporary cash.

The Resolution:
Hari returns the wet money. Anil pays him, starts teaching sentences, and forgives silently.

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Board Vocabulary: NCERT Keywords

Flattery

Insincere praise (Hari's opening tactic to trap Anil).

Modestly

Without boasting; in a humble way.

Grunting

Making low guttural sounds (The well-oiled wrestlers).

Appealing

Attractive (Hari's calculated, fake smile).

Queer

Strange or unusual (Anil's irregular way of making money).

Fits and starts

In short, irregular intervals (How Anil earned his income).

Unlined

Showing no sign of worry or anxiety (Anil's peaceful sleeping face).

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Exam Booster: Essential Questions & Themes

Exam Card

Why doesn't Anil hand Hari to the police?

Anil knows that prison would only harden a 15-year-old boy. By forgiving him silently, Anil allows Hari's own guilt to reform him, giving him a real chance at a dignified life.

Exam Card

How do Hari's views on education change?

Initially: A tool to become a more cunning, efficient thief.

Finally: He realizes "whole sentences" bring ultimate respect, dignity, and honest money—making him a "really big man."

Exam Card

Core Message & Themes

Themes: Trust, guilt, compassion, and the promise of education.

Message: Love, absolute trust, and silent forgiveness possess a far greater powmeess power to reform a wrongdoer than punishment ever could.

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